

Nalanda

Nalanda, for me, was a late discovery. Sadly, nobody seems to go there. What I found totally staggering was how evolved the civilisation that built it was. Nalanda had Asia's biggest library in its heyday. It was burnt down by Bakhtiyar Khilji in 1193 AD. They say it burnt for months and months.

They've only excavated a mound or two; there's so much more to be discovered. Just the proportion of a single brick holds the earth and its ancient tales. Nalanda had a past that is unimaginable and, hopefully, it will have a great future too.

Now that India is in nationalist mode, we are discovering what we were in so many fields. What Mark Twain said about India being "the cradle of the human race, the birthplace of human speech, the mother of history, the grandmother of legend and the great-grandmother of tradition" is truly representative of Nalanda. When Indians go to places like Nalanda they should stop for a minute and say, "Wow, we were all this and let's draw it out of our marrow, so that we continue to aspire to be all that."

Gwalior

Gwalior is a hidden jewel. People aren't even sure if there is anything to see there and if they should go there at all. What I find interesting is that the Taj Express goes to Gwalior, but everybody stops at Agra and comes back. Those who do get to Gwalior realise it's a much better destination than Agra—the latter is very crowded and dirty.

At Gwalior, again, you have a great sense of private discovery. When you go up to the fort and see the Jain caves and statues en route, you begin to appreciate the many layers of civilisation and history there. There are many beautiful temples in Gwalior. The fort of Gwalior is one of the few great Hindu forts that retain its glory. You can get a good idea of the lifestyle of the royals from the size of the rooms, courts and kitchens. Travelling, after all, is also about imagining what lifestyles were in those days, and how we evolved. The sound-and-light show at Gwalior Fort is quite thrilling.





Thanjavur

Thanjavur is the high pinnacle of Hinduism and of Chola architecture. I mean high like 'beyond the heavens'. Just to imagine that you can make a temple with a 700-ft-high shikhara. Then there's the fascinating story of how they made a 6-km-long ramp to roll the kalash up to the top of the Brihadeeswarar Temple. The detailed planning, in terms of how the light enters the temple and falls on the Shiva lingam, is truly humbling. It's not enough to say wow—you have to put your head to the ground and salute the ancestors we had.

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